

- RAG Learning

2.1 Language Diversity (Regional & Social)

AQA A-Level English Language (7702) — Paper 2 Section A

Language Diversity studies how English varies across **region, social class, age, gender, ethnicity, occupation** and **network**. Key concepts are **dialect, accent, sociolect, idiolect, prestige** (overt and covert), and **accommodation**. You must know the classic studies (Labov, Trudgill, Milroy, Cheshire, Petyt) and evaluate their relevance in the contemporary UK.

2.1.1 Core Terminology

- **Accent** — pronunciation patterns of a speaker or group.
- **Dialect** — a variety of a language with distinctive lexis, grammar and usually pronunciation.
- **Idiolect** — the unique linguistic profile of an individual speaker.
- **Sociolect** — a variety associated with a particular social group (class, occupation, age).
- **Standard English** — the dialect recognised for formal, educational and official use. Note: Standard English can be spoken in any accent — it is a dialect, not an accent.
- **Received Pronunciation (RP)** — a historically high-prestige British accent not tied to a specific region.

2.1.2 Regional Variation in the UK

UK English shows strong regional diversity. Each variety has distinctive phonological, lexical and grammatical features:

Variety	Typical features
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Cockney	H-dropping ("ouse"), t-glottalisation ("be'er"), th-fronting ("fink"), double negation, rhyming slang.
Estuary English	Middle ground between RP and Cockney — widely spreading through the South East.
Geordie (Tyneside)	Distinctive vowels, "pet" as address term, "howay" for "come on".
Scouse (Liverpool)	Distinctive velar fricative, affrication of /t/ and /k/, "made up" = pleased.
Yorkshire	Short /a/ in "bath", definite article reduction ("t' pub"), "owt/nowt".
West Country	Rhotic /r/ after vowels, "ee" for "he", "thee" and "thou" in rural speech.
Welsh English	Sing-song intonation, use of "isn't it" as invariant tag, distinctive lexis borrowed from Welsh.
Scottish English	Rolled /r/, distinctive vowels, "wee", "bairn", modal use "need" + past participle.

2.1.3 Classic Sociolinguistic Studies

Labov — New York Department Stores (1966)

William Labov asked shop assistants "Where is the fourth floor?" in three stores of different social prestige (Saks — high, Macy's — mid, S. Klein — low). He elicited careful repetition ("*fourth floor*") and casual utterance, measuring the frequency of post-vocalic /r/.

Findings: /r/ increased with store prestige AND with careful speech. The **lower-middle-class staff at mid-prestige Macy's showed hypercorrection** — producing more /r/ than upper-middle-class Saks staff in careful speech. This established that linguistic variation correlates systematically with social variables and speaker style.

Labov — Martha's Vineyard (1963)

Labov studied centralisation of the diphthongs /aɪ/ and /aʊ/ on Martha's Vineyard. He found younger islanders who wanted to distance themselves from mainland summer visitors *centralised more*. Variation was tied to **identity** — language performs group membership.

Trudgill — Norwich (1974)

Peter Trudgill interviewed speakers across five social classes about variables including the /ing/ ending ("walking" vs "walkin"). He also used **self-report tests**:

- Standard forms (walking) increased with social class and formality.
- Women used more standard forms than men of the same class.
- Men *over-reported* non-standard use — **covert prestige**.
- Women *over-reported* standard use — **overt prestige**.

Established the interaction of class, gender and attitude in UK sociolinguistics.

Milroy — Belfast (1980)

Lesley Milroy studied three working-class Belfast communities, measuring **network strength**:

- **Density** — how interconnected one's contacts are.
- **Multiplexity** — how many roles each contact plays (neighbour, kin, workmate).

Speakers in dense, multiplex networks used more local vernacular forms. Those with looser networks (often women) used more standard forms. Shifted the field from simple class categories to **network** as an explanatory variable.

Cheshire — Reading (1982)

Jenny Cheshire studied adolescent vernacular in Reading. Non-standard grammatical features (e.g. "we was", "ain't", multiple negation) correlated with membership in tough peer groups — **covert prestige** operating through peer-group norms.

Petyt — Bradford

K.M. Petyt documented H-dropping in Bradford, confirming clear correlation between non-standard forms and social class in a second urban context.

Kerswill — Milton Keynes and Dialect Levelling

Paul Kerswill showed that in new towns and regions with high mobility, distinctive local features are reduced; a more general South-Eastern "levelled" variety emerges. However *new varieties* (MLE) also emerge, so levelling does not mean uniformity.

2.1.4 Prestige — Overt and Covert

- **Overt prestige** — prestige attached to publicly valued standard forms. A newsreader using RP is performing overt prestige.
- **Covert prestige** — hidden prestige attached to non-standard forms valued within a group. A builder using local vernacular on-site is performing covert prestige.

Both forces act on every speaker. Overt prestige drives convergence towards the standard in formal contexts; covert prestige drives retention of vernacular features in peer contexts. Most speakers style-shift fluidly between them.

Applied Example: A Year 12 student might use Standard English in a formal presentation (overt prestige) but switch to MLE features with peers at lunch (covert prestige). Neither is "correct" or "incorrect" — they perform different identities and relationships.

2.1.5 Accommodation Theory — Giles

Howard Giles's **Communication Accommodation Theory** describes how speakers adjust their style in interaction:

- **Convergence** — moving speech style *towards* the listener, typically to build rapport, signal solidarity or manage social distance.
- **Divergence** — moving speech style *away* from the listener, often to emphasise identity, distance or power.
- **Maintenance** — keeping one's own style, neither converging nor diverging.

Accommodation interacts with prestige: convergence may be toward overt prestige (in a job interview) or covert prestige (fitting in with a peer group).

2.1.6 Social Class and Language

Class has been the dominant variable in UK sociolinguistics but is not the only factor. Important concepts:

- **Class-stratified variation** — variables (ing, H-dropping, t-glottalisation, double negation) correlate with class.
- **Hypercorrection** — aspirant classes overshooting the prestige norm (Labov's NYC finding).
- **Bernstein's restricted/elaborated codes** — controversial proposal that working-class speech is "restricted" (context-bound) and middle-class "elaborated" (decontextualised). Widely critiqued as a deficit view. Labov's work on AAVE shows vernacular speech is rule-governed and expressive. Modern linguistics treats this as code *difference*, not deficit.

2.1.7 Occupation, Age and Other Variables

- **Occupational lexis** — field-specific jargon, acronyms, genres (medical, legal, IT).
- **Age** — variation across generations; younger speakers often lead sound change (Labov).
- **Anti-language** (Halliday) — a variety used by groups on the margins of society to construct an alternative identity (e.g. prison argot, criminal cant).
- **Style-shifting** — the same speaker adjusting register across contexts.
- **Idiolect** — no two speakers are exactly alike; individual variation exists within every social category.

2.1.8 Community of Practice

Eckert and McConnell-Ginet (1992) proposed the **community of practice** as an alternative to static class categories. A community of practice is a group that coheres around shared practices and goals (e.g. a sports team, a school clique, a workplace). Members develop shared repertoires including linguistic ones.

Benefit: allows intersectional analysis — speakers belong to multiple communities, each contributing to their idiolect. Moves beyond the idea that a speaker "belongs to" a class or gender in a simple

way.

2.1.9 Contact Varieties — Pidgins and Creoles

- **Pidgin** — a simplified contact language developed between groups lacking a common language. No native speakers. Reduced grammar and lexis.
- **Creole** — a pidgin that has become the native language of a community. Grammar and lexis expand to meet full communicative needs. Examples: Jamaican Creole, Tok Pisin.
- **Decreolisation** — movement of a creole towards a prestige variety in contact; produces a **lectal continuum** from basilect through mesolect to acrolect.

2.1.10 How to Analyse a Diversity Text at A-Level

1. Identify the **variety**: which region, class, age, ethnicity or community?
2. Identify **specific features**: phonology (H-dropping, t-glottalisation), lexis (dialect words, slang), grammar (non-standard forms, double negation), prosody.
3. Link to **named studies**: Labov, Trudgill, Milroy, Cheshire, Petyt, Kerswill.
4. Apply **concepts**: overt/covert prestige, accommodation, network density, community of practice.
5. Engage with **attitudes**: how is the variety typically perceived? What ideological work does this do?
6. Evaluate: avoid deficit framing; acknowledge the rule-governed nature of all varieties.

Exam Tip: Top-band AO2 requires precise reference to at least two named studies. Don't just say "sociolinguistics shows that..." — say "Trudgill's 1974 Norwich study showed that... which supports the view that...". Always link features to meaning, identity or social context — never feature-spot in isolation.

Key Terms Checklist

Make sure you can define: **accent, dialect, idiolect, sociolect, Standard English, RP, overt / covert prestige, hypercorrection, accommodation (convergence / divergence / maintenance), network density, community of practice, levelling, restricted / elaborated code, anti-language, pidgin, creole, lectal continuum, code-switching.** Studies: **Labov (NY, Martha's Vineyard), Trudgill (Norwich), Milroy (Belfast), Cheshire (Reading), Petyt (Bradford), Kerswill (Milton Keynes).**